72-Hour Bug Out Bag Checklist

General safety information, not medical advice or a substitute for training. In an emergency, call 911.

From the free guide at https://jaechung-glitch.github.io/bugout/guides/bug-out-bag-list/, which lists its sources. Updated November 3, 2026.

The bug out bag checklist

Work through it category by category. Print the page to tick items off as you pack.

WATER

- [ ] Water bottles or a hydration bladder, 2 to 3 liters per person
  A gallon of water weighs about 8.3 pounds, so carry some and plan to purify the rest.
- [ ] A way to make water safe: a portable filter plus purification tablets, or plain unscented bleach and a dropper
  Most portable filters don't remove viruses, so pair a filter with tablets or bleach.
- [ ] A collapsible water container for collecting and treating water

FOOD

- [ ] Three days of food that needs no cooking: energy or protein bars, nut butter packets, jerky, dried fruit, nuts, ready-to-eat meals
- [ ] A manual can opener if you pack any cans, and a spoon
- [ ] Food for special diets, babies and pets

SHELTER AND WARMTH

- [ ] An emergency blanket or bivy sack
- [ ] A rain poncho or rain jacket

- [ ] A warm layer and a hat, even in summer
- [ ] A sleeping bag or warm blanket if you can carry it
- [ ] Work gloves

LIGHT, POWER AND COMMUNICATION

- [ ] A flashlight or headlamp, plus extra batteries
- [ ] A battery-powered or hand-crank radio, ideally a NOAA Weather Radio
- [ ] A whistle to signal for help
  Three blasts is the distress signal, and a whistle carries much farther than your voice.
- [ ] A phone charging cable and a charged power bank
- [ ] A written list of phone numbers and a paper map of your area
  Your phone may be dead or out of signal when you need them.

FIRST AID AND HEALTH

- [ ] A first-aid kit: bandages, gauze, tape, antiseptic wipes, gloves, and a tourniquet if you know how to use one
- [ ] Prescription medicines, with a written list of names and doses
- [ ] Over-the-counter basics: pain reliever, antihistamine, anti-diarrhea medicine
- [ ] Glasses or contact lenses and solution
- [ ] N95 or dust masks
  For smoke, ash and dust after fires, storms and earthquakes.
- [ ] Hand sanitizer and moist towelettes

TOOLS

- [ ] A multi-tool or knife
- [ ] Matches in a waterproof container and a lighter

- [ ] Duct tape and a length of cord
- [ ] A wrench or pliers to turn off utilities

DOCUMENTS AND MONEY

- [ ] Copies of IDs, insurance policies and prescriptions in a waterproof bag
- [ ] Cash in small bills
  Card readers and ATMs need power and a network.
- [ ] Emergency contacts, including someone out of town

CLOTHING AND HYGIENE

- [ ] A complete change of clothes and sturdy shoes
- [ ] Extra socks
- [ ] Toilet paper, garbage bags and plastic ties for sanitation
- [ ] Toothbrush, soap and feminine supplies

FOR THE PEOPLE AND PETS WHO DEPEND ON YOU

- [ ] Babies: formula, bottles, diapers, wipes
- [ ] Older adults: hearing aid batteries, mobility aids, extra glasses
- [ ] Pets: food, water, leash or carrier, and vaccination records

How much water and food to pack

FEMA and the CDC both plan around one gallon of water per person per day, for drinking, cooking and hygiene. For 72 hours that's three gallons each, about 25 pounds, which is too heavy for most people to carry far. That's why a bug out bag carries a few liters and the means to treat more.

Water

Per person: 1 gallon a day (3 gallons for 72 hours)

How to carry it: 2 to 3 liters in the bag, the rest treated on the way or kept in the car

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Food

Per person: 3 days

How to carry it: Calorie-dense, no-cook food. Food labels use 2,000 calories a day as a reference.

Medicines

Per person: Enough to last until you can reach a pharmacy

How to carry it: In original bottles, with a written list of doses

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To treat water on the move, a rolling boil for one minute is the most reliable method. Without a stove, use bleach: the EPA's dose is 8 drops of 6% unscented bleach per gallon (6 drops of 8.25% bleach), doubled for cloudy water, then a 30-minute wait. Our guide to making water safe to drink has the full table.

Tick items off on your iPhone. BugOut, the free offline survival app, lets you make your own checklists and keeps its guides on your phone with no signal.